



Varieties of Field Theory and the Sociology of the Non-profit Sector

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Abstract

This paper reviews the use of field theory in the sociological study of the non-profit sector. The review first shows how field theory, as a conceptual framework to explain social action, provides a valuable sociological counterweight to prevailing economic and psychological orientations in the interdisciplinary scholarship on the non-profit sector. However, despite its certain shared assumptions, field theory in sociology encompasses three distinct, albeit interrelated, approaches: the Bourdieusian, New Institutional, and Strategic Action Fields perspectives. I comparatively outline the key analytical assumptions and causal claims of each version of field theory, whether and how it recognizes the specificity of the non-profit sector and then delineate its application by sociologists to the non-profit sector. I show how scholars' employment of each articulation of field theory to study non-profit activity has been influenced by pre-existing scholarly assumptions and normative claims about this third space. The article concludes by summarizing the use of these varieties of field theory in the sociology of the non-profit sector and by identifying future directions in this line of research.

Introduction

Field theory has become an increasingly popular conceptual framework within the discipline of sociology (Benson and Neveu 2005; Go and Krause Forthcoming; King and Walker 2014; Martin 2003; Steinmetz 2008). Field theory encompasses both a unit of analysis and a set of conceptual claims about social action. As a unit of analysis, a field is a meso-level domain characterized by its own architecture and a shared orientation among its members. As a theoretical model, field theory embraces a relational explanation for social action, by focusing on actors' structural location and their position vis-à-vis others within a bounded arena (Bourdieu 1990, 1991, 1993; Bourdieu and Wacquant 1992; DiMaggio and Powell 1983, 1991; Fligstein and McAdam 2011, 2012; Martin 2003).

As with other subfields in sociology, field theory has become a common theoretical approach for the sociology of the non-profit sector, with a rich, varied, and growing body of literature that employs this framework (Barman 2007; Brint and Karabel 1991; Cooney 2012; Galaskiewicz 1985; Krause 2014; McInerney 2008; Powell and Steinberg 2006). Given its burgeoning use, this review delineates how sociologists of the non-profit sector have employed field theory. As an orienting conceptual framework, field theory – in its attention to meso-level interactions and structured social relations – has provided a valuable counterpoint to the prevailing analytical claims on the non-profit sector generated from economics, psychology, and political science. Yet, despite field theory constituting a “more or less coherent approach” (Martin 2003:1), different varieties of this conceptual framework exist: the Bourdieusian, New Institutional, and Strategic Action Fields approaches. These three perspectives should be understood as in dialogue with each other, with the Bourdieusian approach constituting

the first systematic version of field theory, and then the New Institutional and the Strategic Action Fields strands successively being advanced to address perceived weaknesses or omissions in earlier articulations of field theory (DiMaggio and Powell 1991; Fligstein and McAdam 2011, 2012; Swartz 2014). In all, as outlined in Table 1, these varieties of field theory vary in their analytical assumptions and causal claims, including their conceptualization of the field and its constituent members, their theory of social action, their view of culture, and their selection of the empirical outcome of interest, as well whether and how each approach theorizes the extent and type of difference made by the “nonprofitness” of organizations in the non-profit sector (DiMaggio and Anheier 1990:137). The essay then shows how the existence of these three versions of field theory has resulted in three discrete bodies of research within the sociology of the non-profit sector. Further, this essay outlines how the influence of each approach on sociological scholarship has been shaped by extant assumptions and normative claims about the nature of the non-profit sector. Finally, the review posits that sociologists’ use of this conceptual framework to analyze the non-profit sector at times overlooks important differences between the varieties of field theory on offer. The review concludes by outlining future ways in which field theory fruitfully can be employed in the sociology of the non-profit sector.

Field theory and the study of the non-profit sector

For the purposes of this essay, the non-profit sector in the United States is defined as a third space outside the market and the government, characterized by the presence of formal, private, and non-profit distributing organizations.¹ This “third” or “voluntary sector” incorporates an array of entities, including public charities (charitable foundations and non-profits oriented to the public interest, including religion, education, science, literature, public safety testing, amateur sports, and the prevention of cruelty to children or animals), mutual benefit organizations (such as homeowners associations, private clubs, and professional associations), and political organizations (which exist to engage in political advocacy and lobbying). Organizations in the non-profit sector are granted tax-exempt status if they follow the non-distribution constraint (in that any resulting surplus from the non-profit’s operations cannot be distributed to members) and if they have a mission that is deemed by the government to be in one of several collective purposes. The non-profit sector typically also is understood by scholars to include voluntary associations – informal entities composed of members with a shared interest – and individual and institutional donors who give voluntarily of their money and time (Frumkin 2002).

Social scientists have been motivated to study the non-profit sector for multiple reasons. First, the non-profit sector encompasses a sizeable component of American society: it is composed of over 1.8 million organizations drawing in over \$1.9 trillion in revenue and relying on over 64.5 million volunteers (Pettijohn 2013). Further, the work of private, non-governmental actors has been deemed by some scholars and observers to be critical to the vitality and wellbeing of American society (Putnam 2000; Tocqueville 1835/1966), given that the United States is commonly understood as a liberal welfare state, premised on the central role of the non-profit sector in the provision of social welfare (Esping-Anderson 1990). Finally, non-profits’ long-standing efforts to provide health and human services have become increasingly vital to individual and community well-being following the neoliberal hollowing out of government in the 1980s (Smith and Lipsky 1993).

The academic study of the non-profit sector began in the 1970s. It was reliant on the ontological recognition of the non-profit sector as a discrete third space in society alongside the private and public sectors, which emerged out the work of the Filer Commission and the pioneer efforts of researchers to generate consistent and comparable sector-wide data (Barman 2013).² Academically, the result of this classificatory move was the creation of “non-profit studies”

Table 1. Varieties of field theory.

	Conception of field	Actors in field	Theory of action	View of culture	Outcome of interest	Conception of non-profit sector
<i>Bourdieuian</i>	Domain of struggle over capitals	Individuals and organizations engaged in competition over specific type of capital	Differentiating social distinction based on power	Shared rules of game but distinct habitus based on position and socialization	Reproduction or modification of field structure	Philanthropy as tactic of symbolic capital for elites
<i>New Institutionalism</i>	Arena of production and distribution of good/service	Organizations involved in production and distribution of good/service	Uncertainty; legitimacy; conformity to institutional processes via networks	Shared cognitive-level orientation based on institutions	Isomorphism of organizations' formal structures/policies	Non-profits as subject to institutional pressures due to production process
<i>Strategic Action Fields</i>	Space of mutual interaction (cooperation or conflict)	Individuals, organizations, and collective actors who self-identify as members	Collective action; social skill; cooperation	Shared rules of game but distinct social skill	Collective action	Non-profits as characterized by social principle of cooperation

(or “philanthropic studies”) – a dedicated subfield around the analysis of the non-profit sector (Hall 1992). From its start, non-profit studies consisted of an interdisciplinary community of scholars, ranging across the disciplines of economics, history, political science, and psychology, who shared an empirical concern for the structure and dynamics of the non-profit sector (Powell 1987).

This early literature on the non-profit sector shared several tendencies given the disciplinary location of early and influential scholars in the disciplines of economics, psychology, and political science who sought to theorize the size and scope of the non-profit sector in the United States (DiMaggio and Anheier 1990; Powell and Steinberg 2006; Sager 2009). First, this literature was characterized by “methodological individualism” in that authors viewed the non-profit sector as the aggregated outcome of individuals’ voluntaristic action (pro-social, other-oriented behavior, such as philanthropic giving, volunteering, and religious participation), as opposed to action generated out of coercion in the public sector or self-interest in the market (DiMaggio and Anheier 1990; Etzioni 1973; Smith 1973). This strand of scholarship assessed how demographic characteristics such as age, education, gender, income, race, religion, and wealth affected voluntarism or focused on the ideational role of individuals’ values and norms in determining such behavior (Jencks 1988; White 1989).

A second propensity in this literature was to assume the independent and distinctive nature of the non-profit sector, as separate from the for-profit and public sectors. At the time, much of the scholarship on the non-profit sector focused on accounting for its existence in American society, alongside the market and government. Drawing from the premises of economics and political science, the non-profit sector was theorized to have been formed in order to meet unmet demand on the part of citizens, due either to failures on the part of the market (actors incentivized by economic gain cannot provide “public goods”) and on the part of government (whose provision of those same public goods was constrained by the demands of the median voter) (Weisbrod 1975; Hansmann 1980). In consequence, the non-profit sector tended to be viewed as an autonomous, third space in society, operating largely distinct from the private and public sectors, which were each presumed to be governed by a different set of values and/or orientation of action (Hall 1987).

Sociologists have entered relatively recently into the arena of non-profit studies (Sager 2009). The move of sociology into this scholarly subfield is often viewed as synonymous with the introduction of field theory to the study of the non-profit sector.³ Indeed, field theory, with its attendant theoretical claims, has been argued by some to embody sociology’s distinctive perspective on this third space (Clemens 2006; DiMaggio and Anheier 1990).⁴ Field theory offers a fundamentally different conceptual framework for the study of the non-profit sector than this existing scholarship. Accordingly, it has been picked up and deployed by sociologists of the non-profit sector, as evident in an abundant and expanding array of literature (Barman 2007; Brint and Karabel 1991; Cooney 2012; Galaskiewicz 1985; Krause 2014; McInerney 2008; Powell 1987). In consequence, sociologists’ employment of field theory had a transformative effect on non-profit studies, challenging many of the initial and long-standing conceptual assertions that characterized the interdisciplinary study of the non-profit sector. But to understand its contributions to the study of the non-profit sector, we must first understand the basic tenets of field theory.

Enter field theory

Field theory is a conceptual framework in sociology that encompasses a generally shared orientation to social action but also serves as an umbrella term for a number of distinct approaches (Bourdieu 1990, 1991, 1993; Bourdieu and Wacquant 1992; DiMaggio and Powell 1983,

1991; Fligstein and McAdam 2011, 2012; Martin 2003). At its core, field theory is distinguished by its concern for the relational determinants of social action at the intermediate level of society. A field typically is defined as composed of all those actors who are cognizant that they are co-members of a recognized arena of social life (Emirbayer and Johnson 2008). This definition of a field departs from other meso-level conceptual frameworks in sociology in that it does not focus solely on those organizations engaged in a similar industry and it is not limited to the dyadic relationship of a focal actor and its exchange partners. In addition, field theory posits that social action is best explained by reference to actors' location in the field. Field theory thereby departs from other sociological approaches that focus either on micro-level or macro-level settings. Any field is characterized by a number of objective positions, occupied by actors, which vary according to their possession of material and symbolic resources. Actors' activity is shaped by their structural location in the field and by their awareness of linkages to and interactions with other actors. Attention to the field as a unit of analysis so entails a "relational" approach to social action (Bourdieu and Wacquant 1992; Emirbayer 1997). The "essence" of field theory is the "explanation of regularities in individual action by recourse to position vis-à-vis others" (Martin 2003:1). Field theory necessarily rejects the substantialist assumption in the social sciences that social actors are independent entities whose possession of essential characteristics (demographic, ideational, and so forth) explain their action (Emirbayer and Johnson 2008). Finally, field theory is premised on the claim that any field contains within it a shared orientation of action for its members. A field is characterized by a distinct culture which then governs social action in that space. In consequence of these characteristics, field theory has been heralded for its capacity to address several long-standing sociological tensions. Empirically, it necessitates attention to both the constraints of structure and the creativity of actors' agency in order to make sense of societal outcomes. The use of field theory additionally allows scholars to both account for instances of stasis and change as well as homogeneity and diversity (Emirbayer and Johnson 2008; Martin 2003; Swartz 1996).

Similarly, field theory offers a different generative lens for the study of the non-profit sector than existing theoretical assumptions, taken from other disciplines, about this third space in society. First, field theory rejects claims that action in the non-profit sector differs fundamentally from that found in the for-profit or public sectors. Instead, the key tenets of field theory are posited to hold across any arena of social action: fields are fields, regardless of whether they are in the non-profit sector, private, or public sector. Second, field theory moves the study of the non-profit sector away from a micro-level emphasis on individuals alone or a macro-level attention to the sector as a whole. It necessitates that scholarship on the non-profit sector recognize the salience of social relations at the meso-level. Third, in its recognition of the field as an ontological category of society, field theory shifts research on the non-profit sector away from its historical tendency towards methodological individualism (that the existence of this third space resulted from the aggregation of individuals' "social choice processes and utility functions") (DiMaggio and Anheier 1990:137) by emphasizing the mutually constituted relationship of structure and agency. In its relational focus, field theory does not presume that individuals' attributes exist prior to or outside of their social context. In contrast, individuals' beliefs, interests, and patterns of behavior (voluntaristic or otherwise) must be explained in reference to their social location within a specific setting, as guided by the field's shared orientation of action and as structured by members' relationship to other salient actors.

Varieties of field theory and the sociology of the non-profit sector

Clearly, field theory offers a distinct and valuable way to conceptualize and theorize the nature of social action in the non-profit sector. Yet, field theory – despite its shared claims – takes

different forms. Three varieties of field theory are most notable in contemporary sociology: the Bourdieusian, New Institutional, and Strategic Action Fields approaches. These three perspectives should be understood as in dialogue with each other, with the Bourdieusian approach constituting the first systematic version of field theory, and then the New Institutional and the Strategic Action Fields strands successively being advanced to address perceived weaknesses or omissions in earlier version/s of field theory (DiMaggio and Powell 1991; Fligstein and McAdam 2011, 2012; Swartz 2014). In result, while these three varieties share overlapping theoretical assumptions, their originators have framed and positioned each as distinct from prior versions and so each perspective carries its own specific implications for sociologists of the non-profit sector. As shown in Table 1, these three varieties of field theory vary around several critical dimensions of difference, including the conceptualization of the field and its constituent members, the specification of how fields matter for understanding social behavior (including a theory of action and a view of culture), an articulation of what social phenomena are outcomes to be explained via the use of field theory, and whether and how each version of field theory specifies the “nonprofitness” (DiMaggio and Anheier 1990) of social action in the non-profit sector.

The Bourdieusian approach

In the earliest and most influential articulation of field theory, Pierre Bourdieu, the French sociologist, proposed that a field be defined as a structured system of objective relations between positions characterized by varying possession of particular forms of capital (Bourdieu 1990, 1991, 1993; Bourdieu and Wacquant 1992). As shown in Table 1, each field is characterized by the dominance of a particular type of capital, where capital is defined as resources (material and/or cultural) that can take on different forms and so provide different types of power to its possessors (Sallaz and Zavisca 2007). Capital is not only economic (the possession of money, goods, property rights, and the like) but also can be social (the possession of networks and obligations with others), or cultural (the possession of educational qualifications). Fields also may be characterized by their own distinct form of capital, as in the case of the religious field, where religious authority and knowledge constitute another source of resources (Bourdieu 1991). These types of capital can be converted by actors into other types of capital and into symbolic capital – the capacity to define the possession of capital as legitimate and so not subject to contestation by other actors (Bourdieu and Wacquant 1992).

For Bourdieu, a field is characterized by a structured assortment of positions that vary in their location based on their possession of the various forms of capital and their relationship to other positions. A field is a “network, or a configuration, of objective relations” (Bourdieu and Wacquant 1992:97). Each field is governed by a “rules of the game,” a set of understandings of “what is at stake” and by what tactics the game can be played. Actors’ attributes and actions are based on their relative location in a field relative to other positions, rather than their own characteristics. Further, the position of an actor, combined with their past history, determines their “habitus,” a shared disposition that is based on a common location in a field and that provides inhabitants with the “mental structures through which they apprehend the social world” (Bourdieu 1989:18; Swartz 1996).

This articulation of field theory also contains within it a conceptualization of action. For Bourdieu, actors in a field are weighted by their relative possession or lack of possession of capitals: a field always consists of “dominants” and “subordinates.” Yet, actors in a field nonetheless will consistently struggle over the possession of capital, the types of capital that matter, and the rules of the game in order to ascend in the field (Emirbayer and Johnson

2008). Thus, fields are always characterized by power, self-interest and contestation, with dominants seeking to protect the status quo and subordinates working to effect change (Wright 2009). At its core, while the types of capital, the rules of the game, and the habitus of actors can vary across the fields of study, a Bourdieusian view of field theory necessarily always views a field as an “arena of struggle for control over valued resources” (Swartz 1996:122).

In his explication of field theory, Bourdieu also offered an account of social action in the non-profit sector. Repeatedly in his writings, Bourdieu (1990, 1998) noted that philanthropy constitutes one strategic tactic by which elites, who already possess various sources of capital, can obtain symbolic capital. More broadly, he posited that economic capital only constitutes a form of legitimate, relational power over others when it is converted into symbolic capital. In part, this conversion is possible when elites engage in “forms of legitimizing redistribution,” which he specified as including not only redistributive government policies but also private efforts, including the “financing of ‘disinterested’ foundations, donations to hospitals, academic and cultural institutions” (Bourdieu 1990:159). Bourdieu intentionally positions this perspective on philanthropy in opposition to the view in classical theory of philanthropy as disinterested and motivated by altruistic intentions, as in the case of Mauss and Levi-Strauss (Silber 2012).

Bourdieu’s emphasis on the role of philanthropy in perpetuating economic inequality has been taken up by a number of sociologists of the non-profit sector. In part, this embrace resulted from its alignment with a prior perspective in non-profit studies, drawn from the scholarship of Marx and Gramsci, that focused on the self-interested work of elites (through personal giving, corporate philanthropy, and foundations) in the construction and composition of the non-profit sector both in the United States and abroad. Rather than view elites’ engagement with philanthropy as motivated by a beneficial concern for the disadvantaged or for the broader social welfare, this literature instead emphasized elites’ efforts to employ their wealth in ways that perpetuated their position in society (Arnove 1980; Hall 1992; Odendahl 1990; Salzman and William Domhoff 1983).

This separate and pre-existing line of scholarship clearly had a striking affinity with the perspective on philanthropy present in a Bourdieusian conception of field theory. In consequence, various social scientists have wielded Bourdieu’s field theory to analyze the work of elites in the non-profit sector (Kidd 1996; Silver 1998). Francie Ostrower (1995), for example, examined charitable giving by elites as a source of symbolic capital, further employing Bourdieu to characterize elite philanthropy as a field in itself, where actors’ privileged ability to engage in the contested act of philanthropy is explained by changing status and ethnic boundaries. Similarly, in a historical biography of Andrew Carnegie that applied a Bourdieusian approach to philanthropy, the authors argued that “philanthropic activities serve to boost the cultural, social and symbolic capital of entrepreneurs and increase their effectiveness as multi-positional agents within the field of power” (Harvey *et al.* 2011:426).

More broadly, Bourdieu’s field theory has been employed in the sociology of the non-profit sector in a small but growing body of literature. In this scholarship, the tenets of a Bourdieusian field theory are applied to the study of non-profit fields without reference to elites’ engagement in philanthropy. For instance, despite critiques of Bourdieusian theory for an over-emphasis on reproduction (DiMaggio 1997; Fligstein and McAdam 2012), these authors have used this conceptual framework to explain situations of change, such as the emergence of a new field (Dacin *et al.* 2010) and the formation of a new institution (Maguire *et al.* 2004). In his history of non-profit technology assistance providers, for instance, McNerney (2008) employs a Bourdieusian frame to show how the creation of that field was contingent upon proponents’ offerings of accounts, defined as discursive rationales for action, that aligned with elites’ interests and that they then adopted as conventions, so serving as the building blocks for the emergent field.

Other sociologists have more broadly applied a Bourdieusian view of the field to better account for the behavior and outcomes of actors in a focal arena of study (Chen 2012; Woolford and Curran 2013; Greenspan 2014). Typically, these works emphasize that a Bourdieusian approach provides a more relational and contextual account of non-profit actors than other theoretical perspectives that emphasize only actors' attributes or their dyadic ties to others. In one case, Monika Krause (2014) employed this perspective to critique ideational explanations for how international NGOs choose their funding projects in the field of humanitarian relief. Drawing from Bourdieu, Krause depicted this arena as characterized both by similarity and by difference. NGOs share a common set of assumptions and activities concerning their shared task. Simultaneously, as predicted by Bourdieu's notion of field theory, the field of humanitarian relief is characterized by competition – rivalry among beneficiaries for receipt of resources and NGOs' positioning of themselves relative to other donors for distinction in the field.

New Institutionalism

A second version of field theory, strongly influenced by Pierre Bourdieu's scholarship, has been that of New Institutionalism (DiMaggio and Powell 1991). As with field theory more broadly, the New Institutional approach emphasizes the field as the critical unit of analysis, but it puts forward an articulation of a relational explanation for social action that varies from Bourdieu in several regards, as shown in Table 1 (DiMaggio and Powell 1983, 1991; Scott 2005; Scott and Meyer 1991). First, the New Institutional perspective focuses on the "organizational field," where a field consists of all organizations involved in the production and distribution of a particular good or service, as well as all those organizations in their environment that they rely on to engage in that work and/or that influence their decisions, including the state, producers, suppliers, trade associations, and consumers (DiMaggio and Powell 1983). In addition, and also in contrast to Bourdieu, this version of field theory asserts that all organizations in an established field will come to look alike in terms of their formal structures and policies. To account for this homogeneity, these authors propose that organizations in a field are subject to both technical pressures (e.g., the criteria of competition and organizational efficiency) and institutional pressures. Institutions consist of rule-like, rationalized, and taken-for-granted understandings that operate at the cognitive level and serve as templates for action and so garner approval from others in an organizational field. Actors' behavior is shaped not by the pursuit of capital and unequal access to resources but instead cognitively shaped by institutional expectations and the pursuit of legitimacy (DiMaggio and Powell 1983; Meyer and Rowan 1977). Later articulations of New Institutionalism focused on the capacity of this framework to account for change and agency within a field (DiMaggio and Powell 1991; Oliver 1991).

The institutional environment influences organizations in a field through three distinct dynamics. Coercive isomorphism consists of organizations being compelled to adopt specific rules or structures due to pressure from the organizations on which they are dependent for material resources and legitimacy, such as the state. Normative isomorphism occurs when professionals – through the processes of accreditation and education – diffuse shared and learned norms and expectations about the proper structure and operation of organizations. Mimetic isomorphism takes place when organizations face uncertainty in their production process (they are unclear as to what to produce and/or how best to produce it) and so instead mimic the established practices of successful members of their organizational field in order to settle on practices and policies. As a result of these three processes, organizations in a field come to look alike over time. However, the relative influence of each of the three isomorphic pressures from the institutional environment depends on the extent of structuration of the field. As an

organizational field becomes established, the pressures of the institutional environment (as opposed to those of the technical environment) increases, and isomorphic pressures become more responsible for a practice's adoption than at an earlier stage when technical efficiency prevails (DiMaggio and Powell 1983, 1991; Wooten and Hoffman 2008).

The New Institutional perspective on field theory is contingent upon a particular depiction of the specificity of non-profit organizations. Empirically, this framework arose out of scholars' earlier study of organizations outside of the market and the observation that their production processes were distinct from firms, so making them particularly susceptible to the institutional environment. Unlike companies, public and non-profit organizations are characterized by "technological uncertainty" (a lack of clarity as to the relationship between means and ends) and "goal ambiguity" (the presence of under-specified or disputed goals for the organization) in the making of a good or service (DiMaggio and Powell 1983, 1991; Meyer and Rowan 1977). Schools, for example, are tasked with education but managers often have little ability to judge and/or improve the efficacy of their efforts (a case of technological uncertainty) (Rowan 1982). Community-based organizations may experience disagreement among members as to the most pressing challenges faced by their clients (an instance of goal ambiguity).

In result, the field theory of New Institutionalism possesses a particular suitability to the study of non-profits given the origins of this approach. Perhaps in result, of the three different views of field theory, New Institutionalism has diffused most widely in scholarship on the non-profit sector.⁵ For example, a count of publications in *Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Quarterly*, the flagship journal for non-profit studies, shows over 110 publications that include DiMaggio and Powell's concept of the organizational field, with many more employing the broader tenets of New Institutionalism. However, this literature is characterized by two contrasting emphases, each of which highlights the "nonprofitness" of non-profits but neither of which extends DiMaggio and Powell's emphasis on non-profits' production processes as determinative of their outcomes.

The first body of literature uses New Institutionalism's field theory to provide a more contextualized and relational explanation for the workings of the non-profit sector so as to move away from non-profit studies' initial emphasis on actors' philanthropic values or utility functions. As a whole, the focus has been to explain non-profits' possession of a formal structure or policy that is characteristic of the non-profit sector. Examples include studies of donor designation (Barman 2008), corporate philanthropy (Galaskiewicz 1985; Guthrie and McQuarrie 2008), government lobbying (Suarez and Hwang 2008), and professional codes of conduct (Bromley and Orchard 2015). Patterns of adoption are explained by organizations' susceptibility to institutional pressures that are operationalized by reference to the specificity of the non-profit sector, with an emphasis on the role of non-profit professionals or board members (as a source of normative isomorphism), the state or market as resource provider (as sources of coercive isomorphism), and the influence of larger non-profits in the same industry (as a source of mimetic isomorphism) (Barman and MacIndoe 2012; Galaskiewicz and Bielefeld 1998; Guo 2007). Following efforts by New Institutionalists to highlight the capacity of their theory to account for change (DiMaggio and Powell 1991; Powell 1987), a later group of scholars has employed New Institutionalism to explain the creation of new institutions and fields in the non-profit sector, with attention to actors' strategic work (DiMaggio and Powell 1991; Lune and Martinez 1999), as evident in the study of the emergent field of venture philanthropy in the 1990s (Moody 2007).

A second set of sociologists innovatively has applied the New Institutional variety of field theory to the study of non-profits through the lens of a long-standing concern about the nature of the non-profit sector in contemporary society. In non-profit studies, one prevailing discourse has been that the non-profit sector's original and unique culture of voluntarism, altruism, and

philanthropy is being replaced by technical-rationality, bureaucracy, and hierarchy (Koch *et al.* 2015; Maier *et al.* 2014; Skocpol 2003).⁶ Non-profits no longer are distinct from but instead look and act like organizations in the government and market.⁷ In this vein, scholars have employed New Institutionalism to specify the field-level pressures that have resulted in this change. In other words, the logic of isomorphism in a field leads the “world of charity” to “resemble too much the world of business” (Simon *et al.* 2006:289). One strand of this literature attributes non-profits’ bureaucratization to the growing role of professional staff (as opposed to charities’ long-time reliance on the amateur efforts of volunteers) in governing non-profits as a source of normative isomorphism (Hwang and Powell 2009; Marshall and Suarez 2014; Minkoff and Powell 2006). Other scholars have tested the proposition that non-profits that possess ties to the market or government (via board membership, staff background, and/or resource dependence) are more likely to rationalize as compared with networks to non-profit members of their organizational field (Suda and Guo 2011; Bromley and Orchard 2015).

Strategic Action Fields

Strategic Action Fields is the most recent version of field theory, and it seeks to synthesize social movement theory with organizational literature. In so doing, it offers a critique of and redresses the perceived weaknesses of existing articulations of field theory, particularly their purported inability to account for agency and change (Fligstein 2014; Fligstein and McAdam 2011; Fligstein and McAdam 2012).⁸ As shown in Table 1, the primary concern of this framework is to employ the concept of the field to account for collective and coordinated action – the ability of actors to join others together to pursue a shared goal. A field is defined as a

mesolevel social order in which actors (who can be individual or collective) are attuned to and interact with one another on the basis of shared (which is not to say consensual) understandings about the purposes of the field, relationships to others in the field (including who has power and why), and the rules governing legitimate action in the field (Fligstein and McAdam 2012:9).

This approach assumes that a field is an invisible structured entity, replete with its own collective identity and rules of the game, which consists of actors holding a range of positions in and who self-identity as members of the field. Actors are of three types: incumbents (powerful actors whose interests have shaped the field), challengers (less powerful actors who envision an alternative version of the field), and governance units (internal actors charged with ensuring compliance with the rules of the field), but all are presumed to possess their own disposition based on their location in the field. Change (in the form of the shifting composition of a field or the construction of a new field) is possible and frequent in its occurrence because some challengers possess “social skill” – the ability to secure the cooperation of others and to mobilize them by framing their own interests in ways that resonate with others. Thus, a field’s identity and rules of the game can be characterized by hierarchy (what Bourdieu viewed as the necessary trait of any field), but the substantive focus of this variety of field theory is on the role of change and conflict in explaining the generation of cooperation (the attainment of consensus across groups based on actors’ negotiation and compromise) as a means to collective action (Fligstein and McAdam 2011; Fligstein and McAdam 2012).

Strategic Action Fields theory gives particular attention to the variety of types of fields that exist (fields also can take multiple forms – they can consist of a single organization, a collective actor/s, a community, or an arena of production/distribution, in the sense of New Institutionalism), and the nestedness of fields in other fields, both horizontally and

vertically. Thus, any meso-level entity (an organization or collective actor) can be viewed as both a member of a field and potentially as a field itself. Other fields matter for explaining collective action in a focal field in two regards. First, events in another field may serve as the catalyst for change in the field of study by providing an opportunity for challengers' contestation of the field's status quo. Additionally, government (in the form of the state or professional/trade associations) plays an important role in the constitution and operation of fields, either operating internal or external to a field. In result, this approach posits that a field at any point in time can take one of three forms: unorganized and so emerging, organized and durable but in flux, and organized and lacking durability and so open to change (Fligstein and McAdam 2011; Fligstein and McAdam 2012).

The implications of the Strategic Action Fields perspective for the study of the non-profit sector are multiple. For one, given its intellectual origins, this approach is distinct in its attention to social movements as collective actors in fields. In this regard, this version of field theory should be more fruitfully applied to some arenas of or types of action in the non-profit sector than others, including the study of initial, grassroots efforts at social change, rather than the work of the already powerful (as in the case of a Bourdieusian frame) or the characteristics of formal non-profits (as in the case of New Institutionalism). And subsequent non-profit scholarship has indeed tended to focus on making sense of either social movements (Cooney 2012; Lune 2015; Pettinicchio 2013) or the efforts of challengers to generate cooperation from others for their alternative vision of a field (McInerney 2015).

Yet, the Strategic Action Fields perspective is not consistent in its conceptualization of the efforts of non-profits relative to private or public actors. On the one hand, Fligstein and McAdam (2011, 2012) assert at various points that their articulation of field theory is intended to hold for all arenas in society, regardless of their sectoral location. For example, in their specification of an "existential function of the social" as the microfoundation of their theory, the authors note that non-profits, like any other entity of study, should be understood as "self-conscious actors [striving] to organize groups toward collective ends" (Fligstein and McAdam 2012:54). On the other hand, the authors characterize fields as ranging in their social principal from cooperation to hierarchy. They propose that fields in the non-profit sector are typically cooperative in their orientation (while government is more likely characterized by hierarchy) (Fligstein and McAdam 2012:90), so notably diverging from Bourdieu's view of philanthropy as a tactic by elites to gain symbolic capital so as to obfuscate relations of inequality in a field.

In this latter view of non-profits as cooperative in their essence, the Strategic Action Fields view of field theory aligns with a long-standing scholarly perspective that casts the non-profit sector in a Tocquevillian light (Frumkin 2002; Putnam 2000; Wuthnow 2002). This body of literature – contra a view of the non-profit sector as an expression of status groups' pursuit of their interests (Bourdieu (1998); Hall 1992; Ostrower 1995) – views members of the non-profit sector as largely "benevolent" in nature and as working towards the greater good of society through the pluralistic pursuit of their own interests and the employment of social capital (Sager 2009:1538). Similarly, this cooperative view of non-profits in the Strategic Action Fields approach typifies the to-date small but growing literature that employs this perspective to study the non-profit sector. Using the case of the Fenian movement, one recent study delineated the construction of a transnational strategic action field that existed across national boundaries to explain the success of a nationalist social movement (Lune 2015). Others have brought in the Strategic Action Fields approach by attention to the strategic work of actors in a non-profit field to gain cooperation from others (Macmillan *et al.* 2013; McInerney 2015). One recent study analyzed foundations' employment of charisma (as a form of social skill) and portrayal of their funding targets as in the public good in order to garner external support as a means to consensus and cooperation (Adloff 2015).

Directions of future research

As a conceptual framework, field theory has been heralded across multiple subfields of sociology, including political sociology (Steinmetz 2008; Swartz 2013), global/transnational studies (Go and Krause Forthcoming), organizational theory (King and Walker 2014), and media studies (Benson and Neveu 2005) among others, for its capacity to bridge micro and macro levels of action, to overcome the duality of structure and agency, and to recognize the relational nature of social action. Similarly, sociologists fruitfully have brought field theory to the study of the non-profit sector, and in so doing have upended long-standing assumptions about the atomistic and unique nature of social action in this third space, as reflective of the subfield's origins in economics, political science, and psychology.

However, it is critical to recognize that field theory itself is an umbrella term that encompasses three distinct, albeit interrelated, varieties: the Bourdieusian, New Institutional, and Strategic Action Fields approaches. This essay has provided a comparative analysis of the key tenets of each perspective and how each has then been employed in the sociology of the non-profit sector, with several critical findings. First, field theory began with the Bourdieusian approach; subsequent approaches should not be viewed as autonomous but rather as branches in that family tree, with later authors carefully positioning their version of field theory as distinct from earlier iterations. We might even consider field theory itself – with its contestations over which version is best – to constitute a Bourdieusian view of a field in and of itself. In result, despite their shared origin and common assumptions, these varieties of field theory are characterized by critical points of difference, including their specification of the concept of the field, view of culture and action, outcome of interest, and articulation of the nature of the non-profit sector.

Yet, in contrast to these perspectives' intended points of difference and distinction, their subsequent employment in the sociology of the non-profit sector does not map neatly and entirely onto each version of field theory. To be sure, a homology exists between these three approaches' tenets and subsequent non-profit research largely in terms of scholars' selection of their empirical outcome of study. Those sociologists interested in the reproduction of economic inequality have employed a Bourdieusian approach, while those interested in homogeneity and/or organizations' formal characteristics have tended to employ a New Institutional framework, and sociologists concerned with social movements have begun to employ a Strategic Action Fields perspective.

However, sociologists of the non-profit sector have not parsed out to the same degree the differences that exist across these three approaches in terms of their specified conceptualization of the field or their causal modeling of how fields matter for explaining social action. For instance, as outlined above, scholars of the non-profit sector have employed each and all of these three versions of field theory to study and account for change and innovation, all have been used as a theoretical frame to highlight the agentic work of actors, and all have been applied to conceptually capture actors' contestation over resources. Further, in some non-profit studies that employ the field as the unit of analysis, scholars have drawn from and referenced all three approaches in their description of field theory (Andrews 2014; Marwell and McQuarrie 2013). In all, perhaps accounting in part for the popularity of field theory in this subfield, sociologists of the non-profit sector have largely but not always hued tightly to the full array of analytical assumptions and causal claims that distinguish the three varieties of field theory from one another.⁹

Secondly, each version of field theory contains within it not only a general meso-level theory of social action but also a specification of the “non-profitness” of the non-profit sector, focusing variously on its role in elites' pursuit of symbolic capital, the distinct production processes of

non-profits versus firms, or non-profits' orientation around the social principle of cooperation rather than hierarchy. However, scholars' subsequent application of these claims in their empirical scholarship either omits such claims (viewing non-profits instead as generic cases of the theory) or has been influenced or even modified by extant scholarly traditions or normative claims about the non-profit sector. In result, sociologists' use of field theory to study the specificity of the non-profit sector sometimes but does not always align with that found in the seminal articulation of each variety of field theory. Other sociologists have omitted the perspective's conceptualization of the "non-profitness" of non-profits and instead applied the theory to analyze non-profit organizations as standard, non-sector specific instances of the theory.

Looking forward, we can expect the growing application of field theory in the sociological study of the non-profit study. First, we can anticipate that some scholars will view social action in the non-profit sector as generic, generalizable cases in order to analytically contribute to field theory as a whole or to a specific variety of field theory. In addition, we should expect that conceptual elaborations and/or ongoing debates in field theory will continue to shape how scholars conceptually describe and seek to explain the composition and dynamics of the non-profit sector. However, given past developments, it seems likely that the continued employment of field theory in non-profit studies will be framed by or even tempered by existing scholarly traditions and normative claims about the non-profit sector.

Finally, field theory no doubt will and should be employed to address new empirical developments in the non-profit sector. For one, the emergence of fields embracing new market-based solution to social problems, including social enterprises, impact investing, and social impact bonds, requires sustained attention. Field theory provides the best conceptual framework for understanding the conditions underlying the origins, diffusion, and likely consequences of these new and much championed vehicles of social welfare. In addition, the resurgence of elite philanthropy necessitates sociological analysis. Certainly, in a new Gilded Age where the uber-wealthy, such as Warren Buffett and Mark Zuckerberg, are pledging to give away their fortunes in their lifetime, field theory promises valuable insights into this tendency and its likely implications for social welfare and each variety of field theory draws attention to different aspects of this trend. However, no matter what precise aspect of the non-profit sector that will come under study, the use of field theory – in its attention to the structural composition, relational ties, and shared meaning of a local social order – will continue to provide the most apt conceptual framework for the sociological analysis of social action in the non-profit sector.

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Short Biography

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Notes

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¹ Such a definition by necessity simplifies the ambiguous and complicated nature of defining and bounding the space of the non-profit sector. For a discussion of the complexities and challenges of defining and delineating this “third space,” see Frumkin (2002).

² The Filer Commission (formally known as The Commission on Private Philanthropy and Public Needs) was created by John D. Rockefeller III in 1973 in an effort to articulate and demonstrate the value of actors in the non-profit sector as a strategy to halt potential changes to the otherwise favorable regulatory treatment and tax policy governing foundations in the United States at the time (Barman 2013).

³ Prior to this point, sociologists had studied particular types of non-profit industries (e.g., hospitals, foundations, voluntary associations) but without reference to their location in the non-profit sector (Barman 2013).

⁴ Another key sociological influence on the study of the non-profit sector has been historical accounts that emphasize the role of power, institutions, and the role of state (DiMaggio and Anheier 1990; Hall 1992).

⁵ In part, the popularity of New Institutionalism in non-profit studies occurred because this theoretical orientation was further developed and disseminated through extensive empirical application of the framework to non-profits, including the seminal authors' own research (DiMaggio 1986, 1991), the 1983 article's reprinting in an edited volume on community organizations (Milofsky 1988), the inclusion of several non-profit case studies in the 1991 edited volume on New Institutionalism (Brint and Karabel 1991; Galaskiewicz 1991; Singh et al. 1991), and Powell's (1987) editing of a volume on research on the non-profit sector.

⁶ DiMaggio and Powell (1983) did not specify such an application of their theory in their seminal article, although they did note the threat that homogenization posed to pluralism as a necessary condition of a vital civil society.

⁷ For discussion of the broader tendency in the organizational literature to conceive of isomorphism as occurring on a cross-sectoral level where all organizations come to look alike, see DiMaggio (1995).

⁸ Note, however, claims that both the Bourdieusian and New Institutional versions of field theory do indeed include the recognition of and theorization of change (DiMaggio and Powell 1991; Swartz 2014).

⁹ This tendency might result in part from the challenges and complexities of conducting research using field theory, as noted by Zilber (2014).

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